

Tokens vs API Keys

Tokens (JWT)

Temporary, self-contained credentials that carry user information and expire automatically. Like a movie ticket with your seat info printed on it.

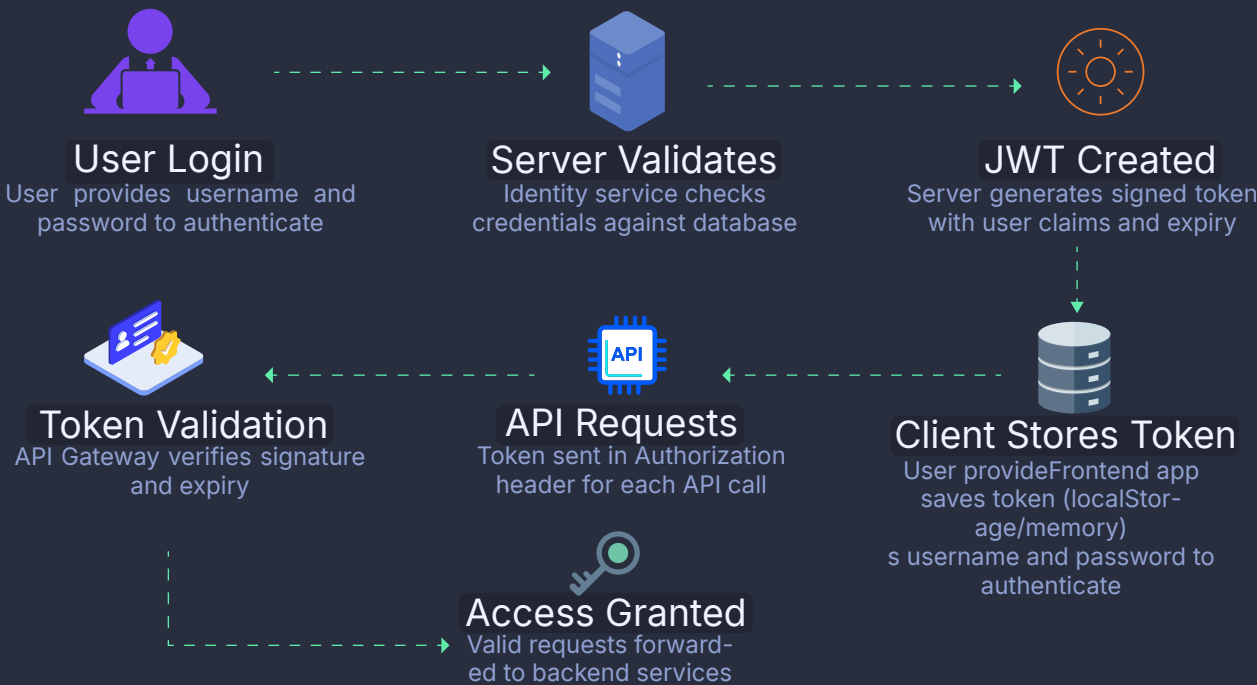
- Contains user data (claims)
- Has expiration time
- Can be verified without database lookup
- Stateless authentication
- Perfect for user sessions

API Keys

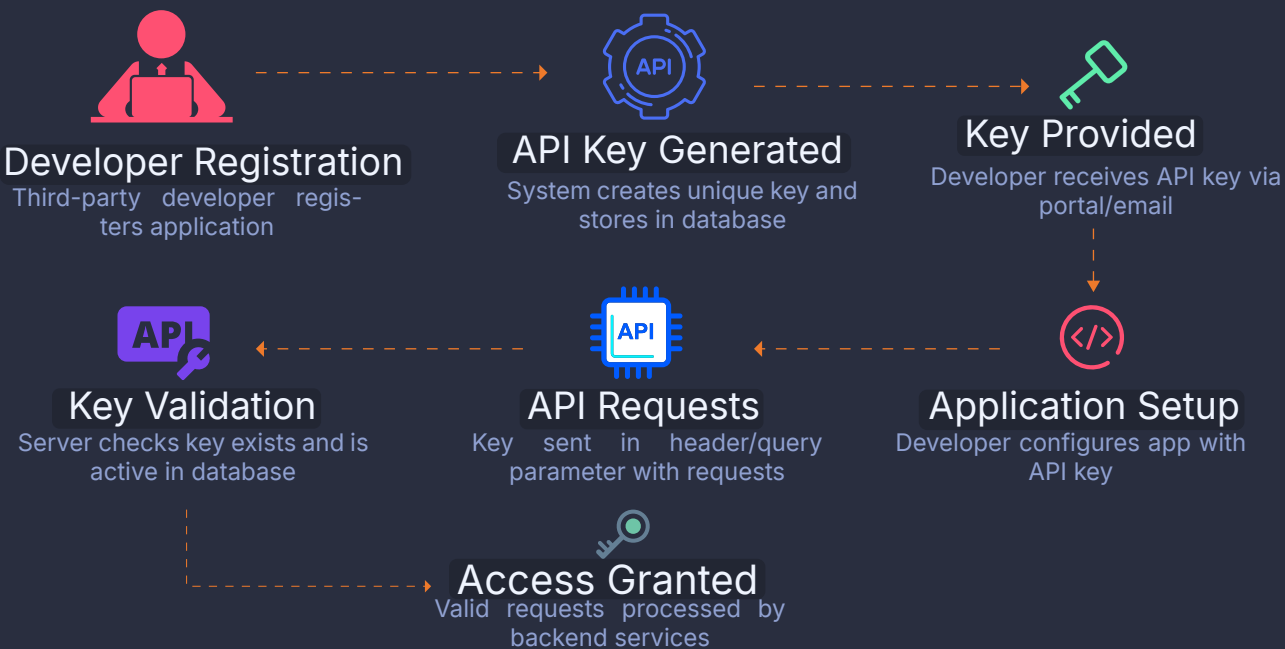
Long-lived, simple credentials that identify applications or services. Like a house key - simple, permanent, and grants access.

- Simple string identifier
- Long-lived (until revoked)
- Identifies applications/services
- Easy to implement
- Great for service-to-service auth

Token Flow



API Key Flow



Comparison

Feature	Tokens (JWT)	API Keys
Security	High	Medium
Expiration	Auto-expires	Manual revocation
User Context	Contains user data	Application-level only
Scalability	Stateless, highly scalable	Requires database lookup
Implementation	Complex (auth flow)	